

The logo consists of the letters 'KA' in a bold, white, sans-serif font, centered within a white rounded square. The background of the entire page is a solid red color with subtle, wavy, lighter red shapes at the bottom.

KA

a free workbook for church communicators

Your First 90 Days

A plan for new church communications directors:
listen first, find the keys, ask your people, then
build the calendar.

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before you start

Slow down before you speed up.

It's your first week. Every ministry leader has stopped by your desk with something that needs to be promoted. You don't know where the logo files are. You're not sure which decisions are yours to make. And Sunday keeps coming.

Take a breath. Your first ninety days aren't about output. They're about learning.

You'll be tempted to come in fast, change everything, and prove yourself in the first few weeks. Resist it. The most respected communicators I know spent their first months listening, learning, and earning trust, and then built something remarkable on that foundation.

I've sat in your chair. I managed web, email, and social for one of Nashville's largest multi-campus churches, and I've spent the years since teaching church communicators, writing the textbook on church communications, and helping churches of every size. This workbook is the plan I'd hand you on day one.

"For which of you, wanting to build a tower, doesn't first sit down and calculate the cost...?" (Luke 14:28)

Ninety days of listening is how you count the cost. Here's the road ahead:

Days 1-14

Listen and audit

Review every channel.
Interview your pastor,
ministry leaders, and a
few members.

Days 15-30

Find the keys

Track down the brand
files, the logins, and the
weekly rhythms nobody
wrote down.

Days 31-60

Ask your people

Survey the
congregation. Bring your
findings, and your
solutions, to your pastor.

Days 61-90

Build the calendar

Plan the big moments of
the year, then the next
thirty days, then report
back.

How to use this workbook

- **Print it and write all over it.** Keep it on your desk. The blank lines are for you.
- **Go in order.** Each phase builds on the one before it. Skipping the audit is how new directors end up redesigning things that were working.
- **Behind already?** That's okay. Start wherever you are and keep moving.

Listen and audit.

Before you change anything, understand everything. A communication audit is simply an honest inventory: what exists, who runs it, and whether it's doing its job.

Your goal: by day 14, you can name every channel your church uses, who has access to it, and one thing that's working or confusing about each.

The channel audit

Channel	Who has access?	Last updated	Working?	Notes
Website			Y · N · ?	
Google Business Profile			Y · N · ?	
Facebook			Y · N · ?	
Instagram			Y · N · ?	
YouTube / livestream			Y · N · ?	
Email newsletter			Y · N · ?	
Text messaging			Y · N · ?	
Church app / church database			Y · N · ?	
Bulletin / print			Y · N · ?	
Signage & screens			Y · N · ?	
Staff communication tools			Y · N · ?	
			Y · N · ?	
			Y · N · ?	

Google your church

Search for your church the way a stranger would. Then do it on your phone. What shows up first? Are the service times right? Are there recent photos of real people? Is there a clear next step for a first-time guest, or do they have to dig for it?

What a first-time guest would find:

Interview your people.

Your pastor, your ministry leaders, and your members already know where communication breaks down. They just don't usually say so unless someone asks. Schedule short conversations, take notes, and mostly listen.

Who to talk to

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Lead pastor | ☐ A few key volunteers |
| ☐ Executive or administrative pastor | ☐ Someone who started attending this year |
| ☐ Every ministry leader who sends you requests | ☐ A long-time member |
| ☐ Your predecessor, if you can | ☐ The front office (they hear everything) |

Questions to ask

1. How do you usually find out what's happening at church?
2. What's working in how we communicate right now?
3. What feels cluttered or confusing?
4. What do you wish the communications team did differently?
5. What's one thing I should be careful not to change?
6. If you could fix one thing tomorrow, what would it be?

Ask your pastor this one: "A year from now, what would make you say communications is going really well?" Their answer tells you what a win looks like, and buy-in from your lead pastor comes before any strategy.

What I keep hearing (patterns across interviews):

Find the keys.

Where are the logo files? What are the approved colors? Who has the password to the church Instagram? This sounds boring. It's crucial. You can't build consistent communications until you know what the brand actually looks like, and you'd be surprised how often these files are scattered across personal computers and old shared folders, or don't exist at all.

Brand kit checklist

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ Logo: full color, one color, and white | ☐ Fonts, and where they're licensed |
| ☐ Logo as a vector file (SVG, AI, or EPS) | ☐ Photo library, with permission to use |
| ☐ Ministry and campus logos | ☐ Templates for slides, social, and print |
| ☐ Brand colors (with hex codes) | ☐ A style guide, even a one-page one |

All of this now lives in:

Accounts and access

Platform	Login email	Admins	2-step on?	Saved?
Website host / builder			Y · N	Y · N
Domain registrar			Y · N	Y · N
Google Business Profile			Y · N	Y · N
Meta (Facebook, Instagram)			Y · N	Y · N
YouTube			Y · N	Y · N
Email platform			Y · N	Y · N
Church database / app			Y · N	Y · N
			Y · N	Y · N

Don't write passwords on this page. Store them in a password manager the church owns, make sure at least two staff members can get into every account, and move any account tied to someone's personal email onto a church address.

Learn the weekly rhythm.

Every church has a rhythm, whether or not anyone wrote it down. The bulletin locks on a certain day. Announcements are due to the pastor at a certain time. The newsletter goes out when someone remembers. Write down how it really works today before you try to improve it.

Our week as it works today

Day	What's due or goes out	Who owns it
Monday		
Tuesday		
Wednesday		
Thursday		
Friday		
Saturday		
Sunday		

How requests reach you

How does a ministry leader ask for help today? A form, an email, a hallway conversation, a text at 10 p.m.? Don't overhaul it yet. Just notice.

- ☐ Requests come in through: _____
- ☐ Average notice I get before an event: _____
- ☐ The request that surprised me most: _____

Ask your people.

Your church members have opinions about how well the church communicates. A simple survey surfaces them. Keep it short, five to seven questions, so people actually finish it. Send it by email, link it on social, and put a card and a QR code in the seats on a Sunday.

Survey questions to start from

1. How do you prefer to hear from the church? (email, text, app, social, bulletin, announcements from the stage)
2. Where do you go first when you want to know what's happening?
3. In the last month, did you miss something you would have wanted to attend? How did you find out about it, if you did?
4. What do we communicate well?
5. What feels cluttered or confusing?
6. If you invited a friend, where would you send them first?
7. Anything else you want the communications team to know?

What we heard

Top 3 things that are working

Top 3 things that confuse people

What surprised me:

Bring solutions, not just judgments.

By now you've seen a lot, and some of it probably made you wince. Here's the difference between a critic and a leader: a critic points out the problem. A leader brings the problem, a proposed fix, and a reason it matters. Sit down with your pastor and walk through what you found.

My findings, in one page

What I found	What I recommend	Why it matters

Agree on these before you leave the room

- ☐ Our top three communication priorities for the rest of the year
- ☐ Which decisions are mine to make, and which need approval
- ☐ How ministries will send requests from now on (one door, not five)
- ☐ How much notice a request needs: _____ weeks
- ☐ What gets announced from the stage, and who decides

About boundaries: a request process protects your time and makes every ministry's work better. You'll explain the why over and over. That's normal. Say it kindly, and keep saying it.

Build the calendar.

A communications calendar is the tool that turns reactive scrambling into proactive strategy. Start with the big moments of the year and work backward. How many weeks of promotion does each one need? Put it on the calendar. What gets scheduled gets done.

The big moments of our year

Event or season	Date	Promo starts	Channels	Owner
Easter				
Christmas				
Vacation Bible School				
Fall kickoff				
Sermon series launches				
Baptism Sundays				
Student & kids camps				
Giving or missions emphasis				

"There's no way I can plan ninety days out." That's okay. Start with thirty. Plan one month at a time until looking ninety days ahead feels normal. Then keep going.

Plan the next thirty days.

Now zoom in. Using the big moments and the weekly rhythm you mapped, plan the next four weeks: what's being promoted, where, and when.

Week of	What we're promoting	Channels	Ready by

Day 90: report back

Close the loop. Give your pastor a one-page summary. It shows what the last three months produced and sets up the next three.

What I learned

Our priorities for the next 90 days

What I fixed

What I need (tools, help, training)

Then celebrate. You made it through the hardest part of any new role.

one more thing

This is a marathon, not a race.

Your work will often be unseen and rarely thanked. I won't pretend otherwise. But you are a storyteller on a mission. Jesus said, "The harvest is abundant, but the workers are few" (Matt 9:37), and you are one of those workers.

My prayer for you, church communicator, is that you'd have the patience to listen before you build, the courage to say no so you can say yes to what matters most, and joy in the work, even on the hardest Monday. Don't burn out. This job needs you for the long haul.

— *Katie*

Want a second set of eyes?

If you'd like help with any part of this plan, I work with churches of every size:

- **Digital Secret Shopper:** I look at your website, social, and email the way a first-time guest would, then send you a written report.
- **Communication Audit:** a full outside review of your channels with a clear action plan.
- **Free 5-minute quiz:** score your church's communications at katieallred.com/rate-your-communications.

Book a free call
meetwithkatie.com

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